These lives have been twisted out of shape by the history of our times, so much so that they become shadows of their former selves, trapped, manipulated, always on the run, always with too many secrets crowded into their fragile minds. Death, preferably the death of a martyr, then becomes an apotheosis. In death they can become an abstraction, a dull average standard of ideal machismo for some and the remorseless death mask of the 'terrorist' for others. There is nothing to look forward to in this death, it is to me far less attractive than the promise of the people they still would have been if they had remained alive. Afzal's impending death will diminish us all, because in his dying, our times will have cheated us of a life that could have made a difference to very many people. All we gain is a composite image, a face made up of the features of Maqbool Butt and Mohammad Afzal and the countless others whose lives have ended brutally, whose lives have been annexed to the closely interwoven annals of martyrdom and terror. In the end, they become only numbers, so many hundreds of 'terrorists' neutralized for the sake of defending the Indian republic, or so many martyrs sacrificed for freedom in Kashmir. These numbers replace moments, memories, conversations, and the million uncountable things that make up the complexity of a single life. Even the life of a man sitting in a condemned cell in Tihar Jail. Counting days, counting hours, reading what may be his last novel, perhaps writing what might be his last few letters.

Francis Galton's racially motivated pseudo-science died a quiet death, and persists mainly as an object lesson in the dangers of the attempt to harvest truths about the human condition on the basis of numbers alone. But it is making a quiet back-door entry through the new sciences of biometrics that are at the core of the information technology of the war against terrorism—which itself is the key operation of the setting up of a new kind of State machinery predicated on the hyperintensive surveillance of those it rules. This includes the impossible holy grail of machine-assisted facial recognition as a preventive forensic measure designed to identify and neutralize potential terrorists. This would mean giving a scientific edge to, say, the act of hanging Mohammad Afzal Guru, were it to take place, before, not after 13 December.

In some crude ways this pre-cognitive neutralization of the terrorist-to-be is already a refined science in Indian statecraft. It includes the provisions of the Armed Forces Special Powers Act (AFSPA) which enable armed forces personnel to shoot to kill on the basis of suspicion. It is the theory of the practice known as the 'encounter'. Last week [early October 2006], even as